

Chapter Ten

Sunday Dinner

By Sunday evening, Nora had apologized to Adam three times.

Once by phone, poorly.

Once by message, too formally.

Once in person, standing in the hallway outside her mother's apartment with a bag of oranges in her hands and dread sitting beneath her ribs like a stone.

Adam listened each time.

Accepted each time.

But forgiveness, Nora was learning, did not always return things to their former shape.

Sometimes forgiveness only meant the wound had stopped bleeding in public.

"You don't have to do this," Adam said.

They stood outside apartment 2C, where Nora had grown up hearing her mother's voice through the door before she ever opened it. Even now, the apartment gave itself away in layers: garlic, roasted chicken, floor polish, her nephews shouting somewhere inside, her mother telling someone not to touch something with dirty hands.

A normal Sunday.

The most dangerous kind of day.

"I do," Nora said.

Adam looked at her. "Why?"

Because my mother already thinks I'm hiding.

Because my brothers already think I make things bigger than they are.

Because if I don't come, everyone will talk about me like I am a locked room they have earned the right to open.

Because I am afraid that if I keep disappearing from ordinary life, ordinary life will stop saving a place for me.

Instead, she said, "Because she cooked."

Adam's mouth softened. "That is a terrible reason."

"It is the family reason."

Before he could answer, the door opened.

Her brother Luis stood there holding a wooden spoon.

He was thirty-three, broad-shouldered, already laughing at something before he knew what it was. Luis had inherited their father's warm face and their mother's ability to turn concern into a command. He looked from Nora to Adam, then to the oranges in Nora's hands.

"You brought fruit," he said. "That means you're either guilty or poor."

Nora stared at him.

Then, to her own surprise, she laughed.

Luis grinned and pulled her into a hug with one arm, spoon still in his other hand. He smelled like onions and aftershave.

"There she is," he said into her hair. "The missing woman."

Nora stiffened.

Luis did not notice.

Or he noticed and chose to make it a joke, which was sometimes worse.

Adam's hand brushed lightly against Nora's back, asking without asking.

She stepped inside.

The apartment was warm and crowded with the kind of noise that used to exhaust Nora in a simple way. Her nephews ran past her, one wearing a cape, the other holding a plastic dinosaur by the tail. Her older brother Daniel sat at the dining table helping the younger boy draw something that looked like either a spaceship or a very serious potato.

This Daniel was Nora's brother.

Not the stranger from the grocery store.

Still, the name made her stomach tighten.

Daniel Reyes looked up and smiled. He was thirty-six, quieter than Luis, with a steady seriousness that made people mistake him for less emotional than he was. His two sons were tangled around him like vines.

"Nora," he said. "You live."

"So I've been told."

He stood and hugged her, gentler than Luis had. Daniel had always hugged as if he feared breaking something but would never admit it.

Adam shook both brothers' hands. Luis clapped him on the shoulder. Daniel asked about work. The usual choreography began around Nora, familiar enough to hurt.

Then her mother appeared from the kitchen.

"Nora."

Carmen Reyes did not walk into rooms. She arrived in them. Small, sharp-eyed, still beautiful in a way that had learned not to ask permission, she wiped her hands on a towel and looked Nora over from head to toe.

"You look thin."

"Hello to you too."

"You look tired."

"I missed you too, Mom."

Carmen kissed her cheek, then Adam's. "At least Adam looks like he sleeps."

Adam, traitor that he was, smiled politely. "Good to see you."

"You too. Come. Food is almost ready."

That was Carmen's love language: come, eat, don't argue.

Nora followed everyone into the dining room, where the table had been extended with the old folding piece that never sat evenly in the middle. There were too many plates, too many glasses, too much food. Chicken, rice, vegetables, salad, bread, a bowl of olives no one ever finished.

Her nephews argued about who got the blue cup.

Luis told them the blue cup was cursed.

Daniel told him not to start.

Carmen shouted from the kitchen that no cup was cursed in her house.

Adam laughed.

Nora looked around the table and felt, for one brief second, a longing so sudden it almost knocked the breath from her.

This was what she had been trying to return to.

Not perfection.

Not peace.

Just a room where everyone belonged to their own body.

Dinner began loudly.

Luis announced that he had news and then refused to say what it was until everyone guessed.

"You're moving," Daniel said.

"No."

“You got a dog,” Nora said.

“I wish.”

“You’re dating someone,” Carmen said.

Luis pointed the spoon at her. “Why do you say that like an accusation?”

“Because with you it usually becomes a family problem.”

Daniel’s eldest son shouted, “Uncle Luis has a girlfriend!”

Luis covered his heart. “Betrayed by the youth.”

There was laughter.

Nora smiled because she knew how.

Across from her, Adam watched quietly. Not suspiciously. Not clinically. Just present. He had agreed before they entered that he would not hover, would not ask her every five minutes if she felt pressure, would not treat her like a glass object in front of her family.

Still, he noticed everything.

When Nora stopped eating.

When her fingers tightened around her fork.

When Carmen asked, “So what has been happening with you?” in a tone that sounded casual only to people who had not been raised by her.

Nora took a sip of water. “Work. Life.”

“That means nothing.”

“It means work and life.”

Luis leaned back. “She’s being mysterious.”

“I’m being boring.”

“You’ve never been boring,” Daniel said.

It should have been kind.

It sounded like evidence.

Nora looked down at her plate.

Carmen served more rice onto Adam's plate without asking.
"Adam says you have been stressed."

Nora's head lifted.

Adam froze.

The table quieted by half a degree.

"I said it had been a difficult week," Adam said carefully.

Carmen looked at Nora. "And that is different?"

"Yes," Nora said.

Her mother's eyebrows rose. "How?"

Because stress is something ordinary people are allowed to have.
Difficult is something other people decide needs managing.

But the words were too large for the table.

"It just is," Nora said.

Luis glanced between them. "Okay, what did I miss?"

"Nothing," Nora said.

Daniel's youngest dropped his fork. The sound was small, but
Nora flinched.

Adam saw it.

Daniel saw Adam see it.

That was how concern became a net.

Invisible at first.

Then tightening.

“Nora,” Daniel said softly, “are you okay?”

There was nothing wrong with the question.

That was the cruelty of it.

Nora could not say no without opening the room. She could not say yes without lying. She could not explain the truth without becoming impossible.

“I’m fine.”

Luis groaned. “Ah, the famous fine.”

“Luis,” Adam said.

The room went still.

It was not sharp, the way Adam said it. Only firm.

But Adam rarely corrected her brothers. He preferred diplomacy. Careful exits. Soft redirections.

Luis lifted both hands. “I’m joking.”

“I know,” Adam said. “But maybe don’t.”

Nora stared at her plate.

Heat climbed her neck.

Now everyone knew there was something to protect.

Which meant everyone knew there was something wrong.

Carmen set down the serving spoon. “What is going on?”

“Nothing,” Nora said.

Her mother’s face hardened with worry. “Do not say nothing when clearly everyone at this table knows something except me.”

“No one knows anything.”

“Nora.”

There it was again.

Her name as a door being forced open.

“I said I’m fine.”

“And I am saying you are not.”

The words hit too hard.

Nora pushed back her chair.

Adam turned toward her. “Nora.”

“I need air.”

Luis’s face shifted from teasing to concern. “Nor—”

“Please don’t.”

She left the table before anyone could follow.

The hallway outside the apartment was cooler. Nora leaned against the wall near the stairs and pressed both hands to her eyes.

No pressure.

No thread.

No door.

Only humiliation.

The ordinary kind.

The family kind.

That made it worse.

Inside, voices lowered. Her name moved among them, muffled by the door.

Nora laughed once, quietly.

Of course.

Even when she left the room, she stayed inside the conversation.

The apartment door opened.

She expected Adam.

It was Daniel.

Her brother stepped into the hallway and closed the door gently behind him.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Then he leaned against the opposite wall, hands in his pockets.

“I didn’t come to drag you back in.”

“Congratulations on your restraint.”

He accepted the edge in her voice without reacting. Daniel had always been better at silence than Luis. Worse at naming it.

“You scared Mom,” he said.

“Existing scares Mom.”

“That’s not fair.”

“No,” Nora said. “It isn’t.”

Daniel looked down.

He seemed older suddenly. Tired in a way she had not noticed at dinner. There were faint shadows beneath his eyes. A small stain on his sleeve, probably from one of the boys.

“Nora,” he said, “Luis jokes because he doesn’t know what to do. Mom interrogates because she doesn’t know what to do. I ask if you’re okay because I don’t know what to do.”

She looked away.

“I know we’re bad at it,” he continued.

“At what?”

“The feeling stuff.”

Despite herself, Nora almost smiled.

“The feeling stuff?”

“You know what I mean.”

“I really do.”

He breathed out through his nose. Almost a laugh. Almost not.

“When you were little,” he said, “you used to cry when Luis and I fought.”

“You fought all the time.”

“Exactly. So you cried a lot.”

Nora looked at him.

Daniel’s gaze stayed on the floor.

“I used to think you were just sensitive,” he said. “Then dramatic. Then older me decided young me was an idiot and maybe you were just the only one in the house reacting honestly.”

The sentence entered her quietly.

She did not know where to put it.

Daniel rubbed the back of his neck. “I’m not good at saying things.”

“No,” Nora said softly. “You’re not.”

“But I can stand here.”

Her throat tightened.

For a moment, she was twelve again, sitting on the back steps while her brothers argued upstairs, wishing for a sister who would sit beside her and understand without making the feeling smaller.

Daniel had not been that.

Luis had not been that.

But maybe they had been boys inside their own weather, doing badly what they did not know how to do well.

Nora closed her eyes.

Then the hallway tilted.

Just slightly.

Her eyes snapped open.

Daniel was still there.

But something had shifted.

Not behind her eyes.

Around him.

A sorrow moved beneath his face, quick and hidden. Not loud enough to become a jump. Not yet. But present. A bruise beneath the surface of his calm.

Nora stared.

Daniel frowned. "What?"

She had spent her whole life thinking Daniel did not feel things deeply because he did not show them.

Now she could feel grief moving behind him like dark water.

"Daniel," she said carefully, "is something wrong?"

His expression closed so fast it answered her.

"No."

There it was.

The family inheritance.

A lie shaped like protection.

Nora almost laughed.

Of course.

Of course everyone had private rooms.

Even the people who had taught her not to knock too loudly.

“Daniel.”

He pushed away from the wall. “We should go back in.”

“What aren’t you telling us?”

He froze.

The question echoed too closely.

Maya in the flower shop.

Adam on the phone.

Nora accusing.

Nora invading.

Nora turning a shadow into a weapon.

She stepped back.

“I’m sorry,” she said quickly. “Forget I asked.”

But Daniel was watching her now.

Really watching.

“How did you know?”

Her stomach dropped.

“I didn’t.”

“You did.”

“No, I guessed. You looked—”

“Don’t.”

His voice was quiet, but sharp.

For the first time in years, Nora saw her older brother not as the steady one, not as someone’s father, not as the calm middle space between Luis and their mother, but as a person standing guard over pain.

And she had almost reached for the lock.

“I’m sorry,” she said again.

Daniel’s jaw worked.

For a second, she thought he would leave.

Instead, he looked toward the closed apartment door and lowered his voice.

“Emma and I are separating.”

Nora went still.

Emma.

His wife.

The mother of his boys.

“What?”

“It’s not final.”

The words were too fast.

Too practiced.

“It’s not final,” he repeated. “We’re just... trying space.”

Nora thought of him at the table, helping his son draw a spaceship or a potato. Thought of the stain on his sleeve. The tiredness under his eyes.

“Does Mom know?”

“No.”

“Luis?”

“No.”

“Adam?”

He gave her a look. “Why would Adam know?”

“Right. Sorry.”

Daniel looked away.

“I was going to tell everyone tonight,” he said. “Then Luis had his news. And Mom cooked too much. And the boys were happy. So I didn’t.”

Nora’s chest ached.

It was such a human kind of cowardice.

Tender and unfair.

“Daniel.”

“Please don’t do the thing.”

“What thing?”

“The thing where you feel it so hard I have to comfort you about my life.”

The words struck her.

Not cruelly.

Precisely.

Nora stepped back as if distance could prove she had learned something.

“Okay,” she said.

Daniel looked surprised.

She swallowed. “I’m sorry. Okay.”

For a long moment, he only looked at her.

Then his face changed.

Some of the guard lowered.

“I don’t know how to tell the boys,” he said.

The confession was small.

Devastating.

Nora did not move toward him.

She wanted to.

Every part of her wanted to close the distance, wrap her arms around him, ask too many questions, become useful before she became afraid.

Instead, she asked, “Do you want advice, or do you want me to stand here?”

Daniel blinked.

Then a tired smile pulled at his mouth.

“Stand here.”

So she did.

They stood together in the hallway, brother and sister, saying nothing.

For once, Nora did not enter the room of someone else’s pain.

She waited outside the door.

And somehow, that felt harder.

After a while, Daniel wiped his face roughly with one hand, though no tears had fallen.

“You’re being weirdly mature,” he said.

“Don’t tell anyone. It’ll ruin my brand.”

He laughed.

A real laugh.

Small, but real.

The apartment door opened again.

This time it was Adam.

He looked from Nora to Daniel, reading the air too quickly.

“Everything okay?”

Daniel straightened.

There was the mask again.

But not fully.

“Yeah,” he said. “Sibling conference.”

Adam’s eyes moved to Nora.

She gave the smallest nod she could.

Not now.

Not yours to fix.

Adam understood.

He looked almost proud, then wisely hid it.

From inside, Carmen called, “If you are all finished whispering about me, the food is getting cold.”

Daniel opened the door. “No one is whispering about you, Mom.”

“That is exactly what whispering people say.”

Luis shouted, “I am eating Nora’s chicken if she doesn’t come back.”

Nora stepped inside before Daniel.

“Touch my plate and lose a hand.”

Luis grinned. “There she is.”

This time, the words did not hurt as much.

Dinner resumed.

Not smoothly. Not without glances. But it resumed.

Luis finally announced that his news was, in fact, a girlfriend. Carmen immediately asked too many questions. Daniel’s boys asked if she liked dinosaurs. Adam refilled Nora’s water without making it obvious. Daniel sat beside his children and carried his secret quietly, but not invisibly anymore.

Nora noticed.

She let herself notice.

She did not take it.

That distinction mattered.

Later, while Carmen packed leftovers into containers no one had requested, Nora stood at the sink washing dishes.

Her mother came beside her with a towel.

For a while they worked in silence.

Then Carmen said, “You are not fine.”

Nora almost laughed.

“No.”

Her mother dried a plate slowly.

“But you are here,” Carmen said.

Nora looked at her.

Carmen did not look back. She placed the plate in the cabinet.

“Sometimes here is enough for one dinner.”

It was not an apology.

Carmen did not have many of those.

But it was a form of mercy.

Nora accepted it.

When she and Adam left, Daniel hugged her at the door.

This time, he held on a second longer.

“Don’t tell,” he whispered.

“I won’t.”

“I mean it.”

“I know.”

He pulled back and searched her face.

Whatever he saw there seemed to settle him.

For once, Nora was glad to be trusted with a secret the ordinary way.

Outside, night had fallen.

The rain had stopped, leaving the street slick and shining under the lamps. Adam walked beside her without speaking until they reached the corner.

“You were different in there,” he said.

Nora looked ahead. “Good different or alarming different?”

“Careful different.”

She breathed in the cold air.

“Daniel and Emma are separating.”

Adam stopped walking.

Nora looked at him quickly. “He told me. I didn’t jump. I didn’t see anything. I just... noticed something, and he told me.”

Adam nodded.

“I won’t say anything,” he said.

“I know.”

They continued walking.

After a moment, Nora said, “I almost did it again.”

“Jumped?”

“No. Made his pain about mine.”

Adam was quiet.

“I wanted to,” she admitted. “It was right there. The old reflex. Ask everything. Feel everything. Become necessary.”

“But you didn’t.”

“No.”

The truth of that moved through her slowly.

Not happiness.

Not victory.

Something smaller.

A breath.

Adam reached for her hand, then paused.

Nora saw the pause.

This time, she reached first.

Their fingers linked.

The contact was warm.

Dangerous.

Human.

No pressure came.

No door opened.

Nora held on.

At the end of the street, a bus sighed at the curb. A woman stepped off carrying flowers wrapped in brown paper. Somewhere above them, a window lit up, then another.

Lives everywhere.

Weather everywhere.

But for once, Nora did not feel called to enter.

She walked beside Adam through the wet city, carrying one secret that had been given to her, not taken.

And though it was heavy, it did not feel like theft.